

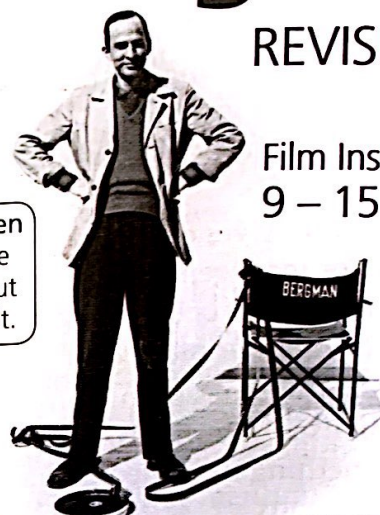
25 State verbs



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REVISITED

Film Institute
9 – 15 May



1 State verbs *believe, have, like, etc.*

There are a number of state verbs in English; we rarely use them in a continuous tense:

✗ ~~The solicitor is doubting the credibility of his client's explanation.~~

✓ The solicitor **doubts** the credibility of his client's explanation.

They often describe states of being, thinking, possessing or feeling:

existing or being	<i>be consist of contain exist</i>
possessing	<i>belong to have (= own) include lack own possess</i>
feeling or wanting	<i>adore desire despise detest dislike envy hate like love need pity prefer trust want wish</i>
thinking or believing	<i>believe doubt expect feel (= think) forget imagine intend know realise recognise remember see (= understand) suppose think understand</i>
appearance	<i>appear resemble seem</i>
other verbs	<i>concern cost depend deserve fit matter mean measure mind weigh</i>

2 Using these verbs in the continuous

It is possible to use many of the above verbs in the continuous, but the verb either has a different meaning or expresses a temporary action:

'Is Maria ready yet?' 'No, she's **having** a shower.' (= is taking)

Santos **is thinking** of getting a new Internet connection. (= is considering now)

Here are some of the common differences in use:

VERB	USE IN SIMPLE	USE IN CONTINUOUS
<i>be</i>	Your son was a very obedient child, wasn't he?	Your son was being very difficult at the weekend; that wasn't like him. (= was behaving)
<i>have</i>	They're very rich. They have three homes and a yacht. (= own)	I'm having a really good time, thanks. (= am experiencing)
<i>think</i>	I've always thought that we'd meet again. (= have believed)	I've been thinking of contributing to Oxfam. (= have been considering)
<i>mean</i>	The sign means 'slow down'.	You're always meaning to call, but you never do. (= are intending)
<i>appear</i>	It appears the police haven't started the investigation. (= seems)	The Philharmonic are appearing at the Palladium. (= are performing)
<i>weigh</i>	She weighs 70 kilos. (= her weight is)	I'm weighing the ingredients for the cake. (= action of weighing)

3 Sense verbs see, hear, feel, etc.

We do not usually use the continuous form with verbs which describe a sense or a form of perception, e.g. *hear, notice, see, smell, taste*:

- ✗ ~~*I'm noticing that your wife never comes to the matches. Doesn't she like cricket?*~~
- ✓ *I notice that your wife never comes to the matches. Doesn't she like cricket?*
- ✗ ~~*I'm hearing that you're not too happy with the management's proposal.*~~
- ✓ *I hear that you're not too happy with the management's proposal.*

We usually use the simple form or *can/could* + sense verb when we experience something without intentionally using the sense, i.e. the action is involuntary:
I (can) smell the fertiliser on the fields every time I open the back door!

We also use the simple form when the verb is intransitive:
The fertiliser on the fields smells really horrible!

With *smell* and *taste*, we can use the continuous for a deliberate action:
I (can) taste cream in this. (there is cream in the dish; involuntary action)
I'm tasting the cream. (the cream might be bad; intentional action of checking)

! We usually use the verbs *see* and *hear* only in the involuntary sense; we use *look at, watch* or *listen to* for an intentional action:

- ✗ ~~*Can you keep the noise down? I'm hearing something on the radio.*~~
- ✓ *Can you keep the noise down? I'm listening to something on the radio.*

If they have a different meaning, we can use the continuous:
I'm seeing a new doctor now. (= visiting as a patient)

! Some verbs of feeling can be used in both the simple and the continuous with no change in meaning:

My wrist hurts/is hurting again – I must go to the physiotherapist.
I think those mussels may have been bad. Do you feel/Are you feeling OK today?

4 Performative verbs *thank, apologise, etc.*

Performative verbs are verbs which can actually perform the action they describe when they are used in the first person and the present tense; they address the listener/reader directly:
On behalf of the company, I apologise for any inconvenience caused.

Common examples are:

accept agree apologise congratulate declare deny disagree forbid forgive guarantee
insist invite order predict promise recommend refuse request suggest thank warn

When we use these verbs in the present, they are usually in the simple form:
Railtrack apologises for the disruption to services this weekend.
We recommend the new tapas restaurant in the town centre.

If we use these verbs to refer to the past or future, we can use them in the continuous form.

Compare:

PRESENT ✗ ~~*I'm thanking you all for joining us today.*~~

PAST ✓ *I thank you all for joining us today.*

✓ *He warned the children not to swim too far from the beach.*

✓ *When we arrived, he was warning the children not to swim too far from the beach.*

FUTURE ✓ *I'm inviting about sixty people to Jenna's party – OK?*

Practice

1 Match sentences 1 and 2 with the continuations A and B in each pair.

- 1 1 Steven's a difficult child.
2 Steven's being difficult.
 - 2 1 This salmon weighs more than six kilos.
2 We're weighing the salmon.
 - 3 1 I invite everyone present to the opening of the new superstore.
2 I'm inviting everyone to the opening of the new superstore.
 - 4 1 The poet appears to have arrived at the theatre.
2 The poet is appearing at the theatre.
 - 5 1 Mmm. I taste cinnamon in this. Lovely.
2 I'm tasting it to see if there's enough cinnamon in it.
 - 6 1 I think house prices will rise again next year.
2 I'm thinking of selling my house next year.
 - 7 1 My sister has a baby.
2 My sister's having a baby.
 - 8 1 I smell lavender.
2 I'm smelling the lavender. It's a very strong variety.
 - 9 1 He's having a shower.
2 He has a fantastic power shower in the main bathroom.
 - 10 1 We guarantee that your child will be supervised by experienced instructors.
2 Mrs Knight's brother and sister-in-law are guaranteeing the loan for her.
 - 11 1 Laura's very sarcastic sometimes.
2 She thinks she's clever, but she's just being sarcastic.
 - 12 1 What are you thinking of?
2 What do you think about the new road layout?
- A He's showing off because we've got visitors.
 - B He's been very demanding since birth.
 - A It will be plenty for thirty people.
 - B It needs to be priced per kilo.
 - A And I can offer you all a 10 percent discount voucher.
 - B I'll put the invitation in a letter to everyone.
 - A There are performances every evening.
 - B We don't know why she was late.
 - A The recipe said one teaspoon only, but I might add more.
 - B I adore the taste of cinnamon.
 - A At least, that's my opinion.
 - B At least, that's my intention.
 - A It's due in July.
 - B He'll be six months old tomorrow.
 - A Is it your perfume?
 - B I know quite a lot about lavender, you know.
 - A It cost more than 400 euros.
 - B Why don't you wait in the living room?
 - A The company takes full responsibility for her.
 - B They believe she is entirely trustworthy.
 - A It's her least attractive characteristic.
 - B Take no notice of her.
 - A It seems an exercise in pointless bureaucracy to me.
 - B You look deep in thought.

- 2 **GRAMMAR IN USE** Read the letter and choose the correct *italic* verb form. If both options are correct, choose both. **2.45** Listen and check.

12 SUNNYBANK ROAD • READING • BERKS • RG2 4OX

Ms Gloria Travis
Pinetree Studios
Loughton LG12 2CO

12 February 2012

Dear Ms Travis,

Please forgive me for contacting you out of the blue. I am writing in connection with the film apprenticeships your studio offers. I (1) *noticed* / *was noticing* an advertisement about these in the Guardian some months ago and I have (2) *meant* / *been meaning* to write to you since then. My request (3) *concerns* / *is concerning* the film editing apprenticeship in particular.

I completed a university degree in film studies last June and I have been trying to find a position in film since then. To be honest, I (4) *have* / *am having* great difficulty and I (5) *feel* / *am feeling* rather despondent at present. My course (6) *consisted* / *was consisting* of most aspects of film and television production, and I specialised in film editing in my final year. I have always (7) *wanted* / *been wanting* to pursue a career in film and I took the degree to facilitate that, although it (8) *appears* / *is appearing* not to have been successful to date. I (9) *realise* / *am realising* that the advert for the apprenticeships was placed some months ago and you may not have any places available now. However, I am perfectly willing to work in any capacity without payment for a few weeks in order for you to see my level of commitment, in the hope that I may qualify for an apprenticeship in the future. I (10) *promise* / *am promising* that I won't disappoint you if you decide to employ me in any capacity.

I look forward to hearing from you.

Yours sincerely

Celia Roberts

Celia Roberts

- 3 Complete the sentences, using suitable verbs from the box. Choose whether to use a simple or continuous form. **2.46** Listen and check.

be despise forbid hurt mean see taste watch

- I'm really annoyed you took the car without asking me. From now on I you to borrow the car without asking permission first!
- That medicine horrible! What on earth do they put in them to make them so awful?
- Oh, Joan, can I call you back? I the grand prix at the moment.
- Hasn't Mike fixed your kitchen tap yet? I know he to do it for ages.
- 'What was that?' 'I don't know. I just something blue fly past. Was it a bird?'
- I'm not coming to the class tonight. I've twisted my ankle and it a lot now.
- What do you mean, you're leaving? Now you over-dramatic!
- I can't understand why the newspapers write such awful lies about people. Everyone that kind of gutter journalism.

1 1B 2 A 2 1 A 2 B 3 1 A 2 B 4 1B 2A 5 1 B 2 A 6 1 A 2 B
7 1B 2A 8 1A 2 B 9 1B 2A 10 1A 2 B 11 1A 2 B 12 1 B 2 A

1 noticed 2 been meaning 3 concerns 4 am having 5 feel/am feeling
6 consisted 7 wanted 8 appears 9 realise 10 promise

1 forbid 2 teastes 3'm watching 4 's been meaning 5 saw 6 hurts/'s hurting 7 're being 8 despises